

RUN-UP TO CIVIL DISOBEDIENCE MOVEMENT

Calcutta Session (1928)

- Congress Session approved the **Nehru Report** but saw discontent among younger leaders like **Jawaharlal Nehru**, **Subhash Bose**, and **Satyamurthy**, who demanded **purna swaraj (complete independence)**.
- Senior leaders like **Gandhi and Motilal Nehru** favoured **dominion status**. Initially proposing a **two-year grace period**, they later reduced it to **one year** under pressure from the younger elements. Congress resolved to demand **complete independence** if dominion status was not accepted by the end of the year.

Political Activity in 1929

- **Gandhi's Mobilisation:** Travelled extensively to **prepare the public** for action, encouraging **youth involvement**, organising **village work**, and drawing inspiration from the **Bardoli agitation (1928)**.
- **Foreign Cloth Boycott Campaign:** Initiated in **March 1929** in **Calcutta**, with the **Congress Working Committee (CWC)** forming a **Foreign Cloth Boycott Committee**. Widespread **bonfires of foreign cloth** followed Gandhi's arrest.
- **Tensions in 1929:**
 - **Meerut Conspiracy Case** in **March**.
 - **Bomb explosion** by **Bhagat Singh and B.K. Dutt** in the **Central Legislative Assembly** on **April 8, 1929**.
 - Formation of a **minority Labour government** in **England** in **May 1929**, with **Ramsay MacDonald** as Prime Minister and **Wedgewood Benn** as **Secretary of State for India**.

Irwin's Declaration (October 31, 1929)

- A joint effort by the **Labour government** and **Conservative Viceroy, Lord Irwin**, to restore faith in British policy.
- **Dominion Status** was stated as the eventual goal of India's **constitutional progress**, as envisioned in the **1917 Declaration**, but without a specific timeline.
- Irwin also committed to a **Round Table Conference** after the submission of the **Simon Commission's report**, but the declaration lacked any immediate or **revolutionary change**.

The Delhi Manifesto (November 2, 1929)

- Issued by national leaders demanding: **Round Table Conference** to act as a **constituent assembly** to implement dominion status, **majority representation for Congress** and political prisoners' amnesty.
- In **December 1929**, **Gandhi, Motilal Nehru**, and others met **Lord Irwin**, who rejected these demands, stating the conference's purpose was not to draft a constitutional scheme.

Lahore Congress and Purna Swaraj (December 1929)

- **Jawaharlal Nehru** became Congress President with Gandhi's support, despite opposition. Nehru declared an **"open conspiracy"** for independence and advocated for a socialist, republican India, rejecting kings and industrial power structures.
- **Key Decisions:**
 - Boycott of the **Round Table Conference**.
 - Declaration of **complete independence (Purna Swaraj)** as Congress's goal. [UPSC 2012- 2014]
 - Authorization of **civil disobedience** including **non-payment of taxes**, urging legislators to resign.
- **January 26, 1930** was fixed as the first **Independence (Swarajya) Day**.
- On **December 31, 1929**, Nehru hoisted the tricolour at the **River Ravi** with slogans of **Inquilab Zindabad** ("Long Live Revolution").

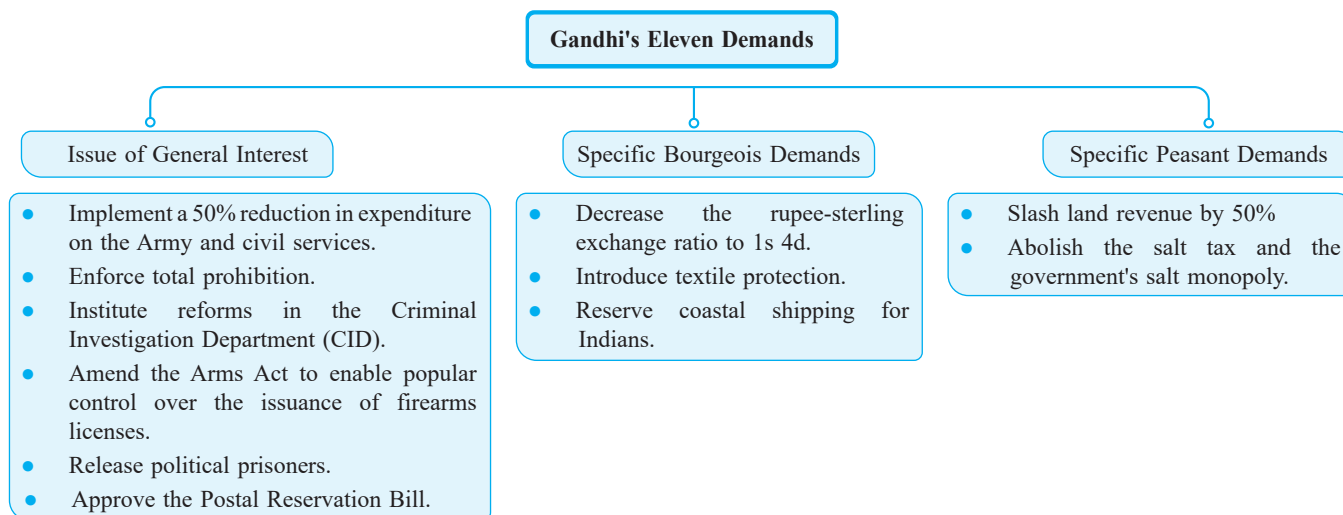
Independence Pledge (January 26, 1930)

Nationwide meetings were held, and the **Independence Pledge** was recited, emphasising:

- The **inalienable right to freedom**.
- **British exploitation** caused economic, political, cultural, and spiritual ruin.
- **Economic deterioration** due to heavy revenue demands, destruction of village industries, and British manipulation of currency and trade.
- Denial of **political rights** and free association.
- The **spiritual emasculation** of India through compulsory disarmament.
- Commitment to **civil disobedience** and **Purna Swaraj** under Congress's guidance.

Gandhi's Eleven Demands (1930)

Gandhi presented the British government with **eleven demands** covering political, economic, and social reforms. These demands aimed to address national grievances, including those of the bourgeoisie and peasants, with a deadline for acceptance by **January 31, 1930**. The British ignored the ultimatum, leading to the launch of the **Civil Disobedience Movement**.



Context Leading to the Demands

- Lahore Congress (1929):** The Lahore Congress empowered the **Congress Working Committee (CWC)** to initiate a **civil disobedience** program, particularly focusing on actions like **non-payment of taxes**. It also urged all members of **legislatures to resign** as a form of protest.
- Congress Working Committee and Gandhi's Authority:** In **February 1930**, during a meeting at **Sabarmati Ashram**, the CWC gave **Gandhi** full authority to launch the **Civil Disobedience Movement** whenever he deemed fit. Recognizing Gandhi as an expert in leading mass struggles, the CWC trusted his judgement in devising the right strategy.

CIVIL DISOBEDIENCE MOVEMENT (CDM)

- Dandi March:** Gandhi initiated the CDM on March 12, 1930 and broke the Salt laws on April 6, 1930, leading **78 followers** from **Sabarmati Ashram to Dandi Beach** to produce salt illegally.
- Reactions:**
 - Subhash Chandra Bose** likened it to **Napoleon's return from Elba**.
 - British media's reactions were mixed—**Mr. Brailsford** termed it a "kindergarten stage of revolution," while **The Statesman** sarcastically questioned its effectiveness.
 - Despite scepticism, the movement's **moral impact** boosted **Satyagraha** volunteers to over **60,000**.

Strategy and Symbolism: Salt as a Focal Point: After Gandhi's ultimatum to **Lord Irwin** was ignored, he focused on mobilising the masses. Gandhi chose **salt** as the movement's central symbol. The **salt tax** represented British exploitation,

making its abolition a powerful rallying cry that led to the **Salt March** and broader civil disobedience.

Gandhi's Salt March: March 12–April 6, 1930

Letter to the Viceroy (March 2, 1930)

- Gandhi wrote to the **Viceroy**, expressing his view of **British rule** as a curse that:
 - Impoverished** the masses through exploitation.
 - Reduced Indians to **political serfdom**.
 - Sapped** cultural foundations.
 - Degraded** spiritual well-being.
- He announced his plan to defy the **salt laws** starting on **March 12** with his Ashram colleagues, anticipating arrest but encouraging mass participation in civil disobedience.

The March Plan: Gandhi, with **78 followers** from **Sabarmati Ashram**, would march **240 miles** through **Gujarat** to **Dandi**, where they would violate the salt law by collecting salt from the beach.

- Before the march, thousands gathered at the ashram, where Gandhi outlined future actions:
 - Initiate civil disobedience of the salt law.
 - Picket** foreign liquor and cloth shops.
 - Refuse to pay taxes.
 - Lawyers to **abandon** their practice.
 - Boycott** law courts.
 - Government servants to **resign**.
 - All actions were to adhere to **truth** and **non-violence** to achieve **swaraj**. Local leaders were instructed to maintain discipline after Gandhi's potential arrest.

Symbolic Action at Dandi (April 6, 1930): The **breaking of the salt law** by Gandhi at Dandi marked the official start of the **Civil Disobedience Movement**.

Spread of Salt Law Disobedience

- **Nationwide Defiance:** Gandhi's action at Dandi sparked widespread defiance against the salt laws across India.
- **Nehru's Arrest and Public Response:** Following Nehru's arrest in April 1930, significant demonstrations erupted in Madras, Calcutta, and Karachi.
- **Gandhi's Arrest:** On May 4, 1930, Gandhi was arrested while leading a raid on the Dharasana Salt Works, escalating tensions.
- **Congress Actions:** In response to the movement, the Indian National Congress sanctioned various actions:
 - Non-payment of revenue in ryotwari areas.
 - No-chowkidari-tax campaign in zamindari areas.
 - Violation of forest laws in the Central Provinces.
- **Government Response:** The colonial rulers declared the Indian National Congress illegal following the mass breaking of the salt law. [UPSC 2019]

Regional Movements during Civil Disobedience

- **Tamil Nadu:** Leader: C. Rajagopalachari, salt march (April 1930) from Tiruchirapalli to Vedaranniyam.; Actions: Picketing foreign cloth, anti-liquor campaign in Coimbatore, Madurai, Virdhanagar.; Violence: Police repression at Choolai Mills, riots in Bodinayakanur. [UPSC 2015]
- **Malabar:** Leader: K. Kelappan (known for Vaikom Satyagraha), salt march; P. Krishna Pillai defended the national flag at Calicut beach.
- **Andhra Region:** Actions: Salt marches in Godavari, Krishna, Guntur.; Challenges: Less mass support than 1921-22 Non-Cooperation movement.
- **Orissa:** Leader: Gopalbandhu Chaudhuri, effective salt satyagraha in Balasore, Cuttack, Puri.
- **Assam:** Challenges: Internal conflicts led to limited success.; Strike: Student protest against Cunningham Circular, which banned students' participation in politics (May 1930). Incitement: Chandraprabha Saikiani, breaking forest laws (Dec 1930).
- **Bengal:** Division: Congress split between Bose and J.M. Sengupta; Violence: Unrest in Midnapur, Arambagh, Dacca, Kishoreganj.; Revolt: Surya Sen raided armouries, declared provisional government.
- **Bihar:** Initial Districts: Champaran, Saran salt satyagraha, symbolic salt-making in Patna under Ambika Kant Sinha; Agitation: No-chaukidari tax agitation.
- **Chhotanagpur:** Leaders: Bonga Majhi, Somra Majhi Gandhian movement in Hazaribagh.; Militancy: Santhals' illegal liquor distillation, local zamindars' mixed participation.

- **Peshawar:** Leader: Khan Abdul Gaffar Khan also known as Frontier Gandhi, founder of Khudai Khidmatgars. Khudai Khidmatgars/Red-Shirts. Repression: Arrest of Congress leaders, Garhwal Rifles refused to fire on crowds.
- **Sholapur: Protests:** It saw the fiercest response to Gandhi's arrest. Textile workers went on a strike from May 7 and along with other residents burnt liquor shops and other symbols of government authority such as railway stations, police stations, municipal buildings, law courts, etc. The activists established a virtual parallel government.
- **Dharasana:** Leader: On May 21, 1930 Sarojini Naidu along with Manilal Gandhi and Imamsahib led a raid on Dharasana Salt works.
- **Gujarat: Impact Areas:** Anand, Borsad, Nadiad, Bardoli, no-tax campaign.
- **Maharashtra, Karnataka, Central Provinces:** Resistance: Defiance of forest laws on grazing, timber, forest produce.
- **United Provinces: Campaigns:** No-revenue, no-rent against loyalist zamindars, active in Agra and Rai Bareilly.
- **Manipur and Nagaland:** Leader: Rani Gaidinliu, initiated revolts, life imprisonment.

The Civil Disobedience Movement (1930), led by Gandhi, challenged British rule through nonviolent resistance, violating the Salt Act.

Forms of Mobilization

- **Prabhat Pheris:** Morning processions to spread awareness.
- **Vanar Senas (Monkey Brigades) & Manjari Senas (Flower Brigades):** Engaged youth.
- **Pamphlets & Magic Lantern Shows:** Spread information to rally support.

Mass Participation

- **Women:** Protested at liquor shops and foreign cloth stores.
- **Students & Youth:** Boycotted foreign goods.
- **Muslims:** Varied engagement; some regions like NWFP saw high participation.
- **Merchants and Petty Traders :** They were very enthusiastic. Traders' associations and commercial bodies were active in implementing the boycott, especially in Tamil Nadu and Punjab.
- **Tribals:** Active participants in Central Provinces, Maharashtra, and Karnataka.
- **Workers:** Participated in Bombay, Calcutta, Madras, Sholapur, etc.
- **Peasants:** Active in the United Provinces, Bihar, and Gujarat.

Government Response

- **Ambivalence:** Alternated between repression (lathi charges, restrictions) and concessions.
- **Round Table Conference** (July 1930): Proposed by **Viceroy Lord Irwin**; failed over demands for **secession rights**.

GANDHI-IRWIN PACT

On **January 25, 1931**, Gandhi and all members of the Congress Working Committee (CWC) were unconditionally released from prison.

The **Gandhi-Irwin Pact**, also known as the **Delhi Pact**, was signed on **March 5, 1931**, marking a significant moment in the Indian independence movement. The CWC empowered Gandhi to negotiate with the Viceroy, leading to the signing of the pact in Delhi. [UPSC 2020]

- **Agreements by Irwin:** The Viceroy, representing the British government, agreed to the following terms:
 - Immediate release of all non-violent political prisoners. [UPSC 2020]
 - Remission of unpaid fines.
 - Return of unsold lands to their original owners.
 - Lenient treatment for government servants who had resigned.
 - Right to make salt in coastal villages for personal consumption (not for sale)
 - Permission for peaceful picketing.
 - Withdrawal of emergency ordinances related to the Civil Disobedience Movement. [UPSC 2020]
- **Rejections by Irwin:** Two of Gandhi's demands were not accepted:
 - A public inquiry into police excesses during the movement.
 - Commutation of the death sentences of Bhagat Singh and his comrades.
- **Agreements by Gandhi:** In return, Gandhi agreed to:
 - Suspend the civil disobedience movement.
 - Participate in the **Second Round Table Conference** to discuss constitutional reforms, focusing on:
 - Federation and Indian responsibilities.
 - Safeguards for minorities.
 - Financial matters, defence, and external affairs.

Karachi Congress Session (March 29, 1931)

Context: Held to endorse the **Gandhi-Irwin Pact**; convened six days after **Bhagat Singh, Sukhdev, and Rajguru's execution**, sparking protests over Gandhi's failure to secure their clemency.

Key Resolutions Passed

- **Tribute to Martyrs:** **Bhagat Singh, Sukhdev, Rajguru:** Congress condemned political violence but honoured their bravery and sacrifice.

- **Endorsement of Gandhi-Irwin Pact:** Congress formally approved the **Gandhi-Irwin Pact**, agreeing to a temporary halt of the **Civil Disobedience Movement**.
- **Reaffirmation of Purna Swaraj:** Reasserted **complete independence (Purna Swaraj)** as Congress's ultimate aim.
- **Fundamental Rights Resolution:** Guaranteed essential civil liberties and rights, including **free speech** and **free press**, right to **form associations** and **assemble peacefully**, **universal adult franchise**, **equal legal rights** irrespective of caste, creed, or gender; **state neutrality** in religion, **free, compulsory primary education**; & protection of **minority culture, language, and script**
- **National Economic Programme Resolution:** Aimed at supporting **peasants and workers** through **rent and revenue reduction** for landholders/peasants; **exemption from rent** for uneconomic landholdings; **relief from agricultural debt**; control over **usury and exploitation**; **improved working conditions**; **union rights** for workers and peasants & **state control** over key industries, mines, and transport.

THE ROUND TABLE CONFERENCES

Background: Initiated by **Lord Irwin** and **Ramsay MacDonald** due to the inadequacy of the **Simon Commission** report.

First Round Table Conference

(London, Nov 1930 - Jan 1931)

- **Opened by:** King George V and chaired by Ramsay MacDonald.
- **Notable Absence:** Congress and key leaders boycotted.
- **Participants:** Representatives from diverse Indian groups including:
 - **Princely states:** Maharajas from Alwar, Baroda, Patiala, and others.
 - **Muslim League:** Led by **Aga Khan III**, included prominent members like **Jinnah** and **Maulana Mohammad Ali**.
 - **Hindu Mahasabha:** Represented by **B.S. Moonje** and **M.R. Jayakar**.
 - **Sikhs, Parsis, Women:** **Sardar Ujjal Singh** (Sikhs), **Phiroze Sethna** (Parsis), **Begum Jahanara Shahnawaz** (women).
 - **Depressed Classes:** **B.R. Ambedkar**, **Rettamalai Srinivasan**.
 - **Labour and others:** **N.M. Joshi**, **B. Shiva Rao** (Labour), **K.T. Paul** (Indian Christians).
 - **Government of India:** Represented by **Narendra Nath Law**, **Bhupendra Nath Mitra**, and others.

Outcome: India was to develop into a federation, There were to be safeguards regarding defence and finance, while other departments were to be transferred. Limited achievements with no major implementation. **Civil Disobedience** continued, highlighting the need for **Congress participation** in future talks.

Second Round Table Conference

(London, Sept 1931 - Dec 1931)

- **Indian Liberal Party** members, including **Tej Bahadur Sapru** and **C.Y. Chintamani**, urged **Gandhi** to negotiate with the Viceroy, leading to the **Gandhi-Irwin Pact**.
- **Gandhi** represented the **Indian National Congress**, along with **A. Rangaswami Iyengar** and **Madan Mohan Malaviya**.

Participants

- **Princely States:** Represented by Maharajas from **Alwar**, **Baroda**, **Bhopal**, etc.
- **Muslim League:** Led by **Aga Khan III**, **Jinnah**, and **Maulana Shaukat Ali**.
- **Hindu Mahasabha:** **M.R. Jayakar**, **B.S. Moonje**.
- **Liberals:** **Tej Bahadur Sapru**, **Srinivasa Sastri**, **C.Y. Chintamani**.
- **Depressed Classes:** **B.R. Ambedkar**, **Rettamalai Srinivasan**.
- **Industry and Labour:** **G.D. Birla**, **N.M. Joshi**, **V.V. Giri**.
- **Women:** **Sarojini Naidu**, **Begum Jahanara Shahnawaz**, **Radhabai Subbarayan**.
- **Government of India:** **C.P. Ramaswami Iyer**, **Narendra Nath Law**, and **M. Ramachandra Rao**.

Key Issues

- **Change in Leadership:** **Lord Irwin** was replaced by **Lord Willingdon**; a **National Government** took charge in Britain, with **Conservatives** demanding stronger governance in India.
- **Gandhi's Demands:**
 - Partnership based on **equality between British and India**.
 - Immediate establishment of **responsible government** at the centre and provinces.
 - **Opposition to separate electorates** for minorities, including **Muslims** and **Depressed Classes**.
- **Deadlock on Minority Issues:**
 - Separate electorates demanded by **Muslims**, **Depressed Classes**, **Anglo-Indians**, and **Christians**, forming a '**Minorities**' Pact.
 - **Gandhi** strongly opposed this, leading to a stalemate.

Outcome: No significant agreements on India's constitutional future. Some **announcements by MacDonald:**

- Two Muslim-majority provinces: **North-West Frontier Province (NWFP)** and **Sindh**.
- Formation of an **Indian Consultative Committee**.
- Establishment of three expert committees for **finance**, **franchise**, and **states**.
- Prospect of a **British Communal Award** if no Indian consensus was reached.

Gandhi returned to India on **December 28, 1931**, with the fundamental demand for freedom still unmet.

Resumption of Civil Disobedience Movement (1931-1934): After the **failure of the Second Round Table Conference**, the **Congress Working Committee** decided on **December 29, 1931**, to resume the **Civil Disobedience Movement**.

- **Truce Period (March-December 1931)**
 - **United Provinces:** Congress led efforts for **rent reduction** and against **summary evictions**.
 - **NWFP:** Brutal repression against the **Khudai Khidmatgars** and peasants protesting harsh **tax collection**.
 - **Bengal:** The government used **draconian ordinances** and mass detentions in the name of terrorism. A firing incident on political prisoners took place in **Hijli Jail** in **September 1931**.
- **Changed Government Attitude After Second Round Table Conference:** British officials perceived that the **Delhi Pact (1931)** had boosted the political standing of the Congress and demoralised British authority. Their new strategy aimed at:
 - **Preventing Gandhi** from reigniting a mass movement.
 - Gaining the confidence of **pro-British elements** such as government loyalists.
 - Preventing the national movement from consolidating in **rural areas**.
- When Congress resumed the movement, **Viceroy Willingdon** refused to meet **Gandhi** on **December 31, 1931**, and on **January 4, 1932**, **Gandhi was arrested**.
- **Government Response:** The government enacted **repressive ordinances**, creating a '**Civil Martial Law**'. Key actions included:
 - **Outlawing Congress** at all levels.
 - Arresting **leaders, activists, and sympathisers**.
 - **Confiscating properties** and occupying **Gandhi ashrams**.
 - Intensified **press censorship** and banning **nationalist literature**.
 - Women faced particularly severe repression.
- **Public Reaction:** Despite being unprepared, the movement gained momentum, with **about 80,000 satyagrahis** jailed in the first four months, mostly from impoverished backgrounds.
- **Protest methods** included:
 - **Picketing** of liquor shops and foreign cloth.
 - **Non-violent demonstrations**, **national day celebrations**, and symbolic **hoisting of the national flag**.
 - **Non-payment of taxes** like the **chowkidari tax**, **salt satyagraha**, and violations of **forest laws**.
 - The establishment of a **secret radio transmitter** near **Bombay**.

- Uprisings occurred in princely states such as **Kashmir** and **Alwar**.
- In **April 1934**, **Gandhi withdrew the Civil Disobedience Movement**. Although subdued by the government's superior force, the people's **political faith in the Congress** remained intact, and the **spirit of freedom** endured.
- **Reasons for Withdrawal:** The movement could not be sustained due to:
 - Lack of time for Gandhi and leaders to build momentum.
 - The masses were inadequately prepared for prolonged struggle.

Third Round Table Conference

- **Overview:** Held from **November 17, 1932, to December 24, 1932**, the third conference lacked the presence of the **Indian National Congress** and **Gandhi**, as they chose to **boycott** the proceedings. This absence limited the participation of key Indian leaders.
- **Indian States** were represented by:
 - **Akbar Hydari** (Dewan of Hyderabad), **Mirza Ismail** (Dewan of Mysore), **V.T. Krishnamachari** (Dewan of Baroda), **Wajahat Hussain** (Jammu and Kashmir).
 - Other prominent representatives included **B.R. Ambedkar**, **Aga Khan III**, **M.R. Jayakar**, **N.M. Joshi**, **Arcot Ramasamy Mudaliar**, **Tej Bahadur Sapru**, **Muhammad Iqbal**, **Sir Purshottamdas Thakurdas**, and **Jahanara Shahnawaz**.
- **Key Features**
 - **Limited Representation:** With Congress absent, most influential Indian leaders either chose to stay away or had little leverage in the discussions.
 - **Persistent Issues:** The issues of **constitutional reforms** and **minority representation** remained unresolved, as in the previous conferences.
 - **White Paper (March 1933):** The conference's recommendations were published as a **White Paper** in March 1933.
 - **Joint Select Committee:** The recommendations were debated in the **British Parliament**, leading to the establishment of a **Joint Select Committee** to analyse the proposals and draft a new act.
 - **Government of India Act 1935:** Based on the committee's report, a draft Bill was produced in **February 1935**, leading to the enactment of the **Government of India Act in July 1935**.
- **Key Facts About the Round Table Conferences**
 - **Gandhi and Congress** participated only in the **second Round Table Conference**.
 - **Jinnah** participated in the **first and second conferences** but did not attend the third.
 - **B.R. Ambedkar** and **Tej Bahadur Sapru** were the only leaders who participated in **all three conferences**.

COMMUNAL AWARD (1932)

- **Announcement:** Launched by British PM Ramsay MacDonald on August 16, 1932.
- **Background:** Based on the Indian Franchise Committee's recommendations, also known as the **Lothian Committee**.
- **Provisions:**
 - **Separate Electorates:** Established for **Muslims, Europeans, Sikhs, Indian Christians, Anglo-Indians, depressed women, and Marathas** in Bombay. This arrangement for the depressed classes was to be made for a period of 20 years.
 - **Reserved Seats:** **71 seats** allocated for depressed classes; seats in provincial legislatures doubled.
 - **Weightage for Minorities:** Muslims received additional representation where they were a minority.
 - **Women's Representation:** **3% of seats** reserved for women in all provinces (except North West Frontier Province).
 - **Double Voting:** Depressed classes had the right to vote in both separate and general electorates.
 - **Labour and Economic Representation:** Seats allocated for **labourers, landlords, traders, and industrialists**.
 - In Bombay province, 7 seats were to be allocated for the Marathas.

Congress Position and Nationalist Resistance

- **Congress Stance:** Strongly opposed the Communal Award but did not reject or accept it outrightly, emphasising minority consent.
- **Nationalist Opposition:** Leaders, including **Gandhi**, viewed the award as a divisive tactic undermining Indian unity and nationalism.

Gandhi's Reaction

- **Perception:** Gandhi saw the award as detrimental to both **Hinduism** and the **depressed classes**, perpetuating **untouchability**.
- **Advocacy:** Called for elections through a **common electorate** and emphasised the need to eradicate untouchability.
- **Indefinite Fast:** Gandhi initiated a fast on September 20, 1932, to demand joint electorates with increased reserved seats for depressed classes. **[UPSC 2012]**

Poona Pact (1932)

- **Agreement:** Endorsed by Ambedkar on September 24, 1932, the Poona Pact abandoned separate electorates for the depressed classes.
- **Increased Representation:** Raised reserved seats for depressed classes from **71 to 147** in provincial legislatures and **18%** in the Central Legislature.
- **Government Acceptance:** The Pact was recognized as an amendment to the Communal Award.

Impact on Dalits

- **Political Dynamics:** The Pact turned the depressed classes into political tools for majoritarian **caste Hindu organisations**.
- **Lack of Leadership:** Rendered depressed classes leaderless, undermining authentic representation and reinforcing the **Brahmanical order**.
- **Subordination:** Denied a separate existence within the Hindu social order, hindering progress toward equality.

Gandhi's Harijan Campaign

- Gandhi launched an intensive campaign against untouchability to counter the British “divide and rule” policy.
- **Formation of Organisations:** **All India Anti-Untouchability League** in September 1932 while Gandhi was imprisoned. **Publication of Harijan:** A weekly launched in January 1933 to raise awareness.
- **Post-Release Actions:** After his release in August 1933, Gandhi moved to the **Satyagraha Ashram** in Wardha, adhering to his vow to remain away from **Sabarmati Ashram** until swaraj (self-rule) was achieved. **Nationwide Tour:** From November 1933 to July 1934, he travelled **20,000 km**, raising funds for the **Harijan Sevak Sangh** and advocating for the eradication of untouchability. **Campaign Activities** Encouraged political workers to participate in social, economic, political, and cultural upliftment activities for Harijans. Undertook two fasts on **May 8 and August 16, 1934**, to highlight the seriousness of untouchability, stirring emotional responses within the nationalist community.

Opposition Faced: Orthodox factions disrupted meetings and staged protests. Accused Gandhi of attacking Hinduism and allied with the government against the Congress. In August 1934, the government defeated the **Temple Entry Bill**, reflecting opposition from orthodox Hindu opinion in Bengal regarding minority status under the **Poona Pact**.

POST-CIVIL DISOBEDIENCE MOVEMENT

The CDM concluded in 1934, with Gandhi acknowledging its limitations and resigning from the Indian National Congress. After the withdrawal of the Civil Disobedience Movement, a two-phase discussion unfolded regarding the future strategy of the nationalists.

First Stage Debate (1934-1935)

After the **Civil Disobedience Movement**, three perspectives emerged regarding the immediate course of action for nationalists:

- **Constructive Work on Gandhian Lines:** Emphasised focusing on **constructive work** aligned with **Gandhian principles**. Promoted **social reforms**, **rural upliftment**, **Khadi**, and **village industries** to foster **self-reliance** and grassroots empowerment. Strengthening people's

power through constructive activities was seen as crucial to **mobilising millions** in the next phase of the mass struggle.

- **Constitutional Struggle and Participation in Elections:** **Supported by Prominent Leaders:** M.A. Ansari, Asaf Ali, Bhulabhai Desai, S. Satyamurthy, B.C. Roy, and others. **It Proposed engagement in the electoral process** despite prevailing political apathy. **Participation in the Central Legislature elections (1934)** as a means to **sustain political interest** and morale without implying faith in constitutional politics. **Building a political front** to strengthen Congress and prepare the masses for future phases of the struggle. Argued that a **strong council presence** would bring **prestige** and confidence to Congress.
- **Leftist Trend Critical of Constructive Work and Council Entry:** Led by **Nehru** represented a **strong leftist trend** within Congress. It opposed both **constructive work** and **council entry**, arguing they diverted attention from the primary issue of **anti-colonial struggle**. **It believed** the ongoing **economic crisis** and the **masses' readiness** to fight created a **revolutionary situation**, warranting continued **non-constitutionalist mass action** instead of political compromises.
 - **Nehru's Vision:** Criticised the withdrawal of the **Civil Disobedience Movement** and council entry as a **spiritual defeat**, representing a retreat from revolutionary ideals. Urged for addressing the **economic and class demands of peasants and workers**, integrating class struggle within Congress through **kisan sabhas** and **trade unions**. Emphasised that a genuine **anti-imperialist struggle** necessitated the inclusion of the masses' class struggles.
 - **Opposition to Struggle-Truce-Struggle (S-T-S) Strategy:** Opposed the S-T-S strategy proposed by **Gandhi**, advocating for continuous confrontation with **imperialism** post the Lahore Congress's call for **Purna Swaraj**. Proposed a **Struggle-Victory (S-V)** strategy, emphasising that real power could not be gained through **incremental measures** or constitutionalist phases. Embraced **Marxism**, articulating the Left paradigm through speeches and writings, including addresses at the **Lucknow and Faizpur Congress sessions** in 1936.
- **Acceptance of Council Entry:** Nationalists feared a split in Congress reminiscent of the **Surat split**, while British officials were hopeful for such a division. In response to these tensions, **Gandhi adopted a conciliatory stance** towards proponents of council entry, agreeing to their demand for permission to enter legislatures. Gandhi acknowledged that while parliamentary politics might not directly lead to freedom, members of Congress who could not engage in **satyagraha** or constructive work should not remain idle. They could instead channel their energies through council work, provided they avoided constitutionalism or self-interest. He assured leftist critics

that the withdrawal of the **Civil Disobedience Movement** was not a submission to opportunism or a compromise with imperialism. In **May 1934**, the **All India Congress Committee (AICC)** convened in Patna to establish a **Parliamentary Board** for contesting elections under the Congress banner.

- **Gandhi's Resignation:** In **October 1934**, **Gandhi resigned** from Congress to serve it more effectively in thought, word, and deed due to fundamental disagreements with powerful factions favouring parliamentary politics and Nehru's socialist agenda.
- **Electoral Success and Internal Dynamics:** In the **November 1934 elections** to the **Central Legislative Assembly**, Congress secured **45 out of 75 seats** reserved for Indians, demonstrating its electoral strength. Despite internal differences, various factions within Congress sought to accommodate differing views to maintain party unity and mass appeal, recognizing that suppression of the mass movement was a temporary solution. Colonial policymakers acknowledged the need for a more

enduring strategy to weaken the nationalist movement by integrating significant segments into the colonial constitutional framework.

Government of India Act, 1935

- **Third Round Table Conference (1932):** Held without Congress; influenced the **Government of India Act, 1935**.
- **Proposed All India Federation**
 - **British Indian Provinces, Chief Commissioner's Provinces, and Princely States** (voluntary participation required for federation).
 - **Condition:** Federation would form if states with significant populations agreed to join.
 - **Outcome:** Federation never materialised due to refusal by many princely states.
- **Residuary Powers:** In the proposed federation, **residuary powers were given** to the **Governor General**.

[UPSC 2018]

Aspect	Federal Level	Provincial Level
Executive	• Governor General: Held pivotal authority as Crown's representative. • Reserved Subjects: Foreign affairs, defence, tribal and ecclesiastical matters, handled by Governor General with non-legislature accountable advisors. • Transferred Subjects: Administered by ministers elected by federal legislature; accountable to the legislature with possible resignation if no-confidence motion passed. • Special Powers: Governor General could act on his "individual judgement" regarding special responsibilities.	• Provincial Autonomy: Replaced dyarchy, granted legal and financial autonomy (provinces could borrow on their own security). -Governor: Retained control as Crown's representative; could assume full control in crises indefinitely. • Special authority on minorities, civil servants, law and order, British business interests, and princely states
Legislature	• Bicameral Legislature: • Upper House (Council of States): 260 members; partially elected and 40% nominated by princely states; a permanent body with one-third retiring every third year. • Lower House (Federal Assembly): 375 members; a portion indirectly elected from provinces, one-third nominated by princely states; five-year term. • Legislative Lists: Powers divided into federal, provincial, and concurrent lists. • Legislative Restrictions: • Only 20% of the budget is votable. • Governor General held residuary powers: to restore cuts in grants, certify bills, issue ordinances, and veto.[UPSC 2018] • No-confidence motions: Allowed in the Federal Assembly, not in the Council of States. • Communal and Class-Based Electorates: • Extended, deepening religious divisions.	• Direct Elections: All members directly elected. • Separate Electorates: Implemented as per Communal Award. • Women's Enfranchisement: Equal rights for men and women. [UPSC 2021] • Ministers and Provincial Administration: Headed by a Premier; ministers responsible to legislature, removable by no-confidence vote. • Legislative power over provincial and concurrent lists. • Non-votable Budget: 40% of budget non-votable. • Governor's Powers: Could refuse assent to bills. Promulgate ordinances. Enact Governor's Acts without legislative approval.

Second Stage Debate Within Congress (1937)

The announcement of **provincial assembly elections** in early 1937 **sparked a debate among** nationalists over strategy, focusing on how to oppose the **1935 Government of India Act** without a feasible **mass movement**.

- **Consensus on Elections:** Congress unanimously opposed the **1935 Act** but lacked clarity on the method of opposition. Congress agreed to contest the elections with a **comprehensive political and economic program** aimed at deepening anti-imperialist sentiment.
- **Ideological Divide:** The **left faction** (Nehru, Bose, Congress socialists, communists) opposed forming governments after elections, fearing it would dilute opposition to the **1935 Act** and divert attention from key issues like freedom and **social justice**. They proposed entering the councils to **create deadlocks**, making the Act unworkable, while integrating **workers and peasants** into Congress for a socialist direction.
- **Proponents of office acceptance** argued for a **short-term tactical approach** in legislatures due to the absence of a mass movement. They believed forming provincial ministries could promote **constructive work** despite limited powers.
- **Gandhi's Evolving Stance:** Initially against office acceptance, **Gandhi** shifted by 1936, agreeing to experiment with the formation of **Congress ministries**. In the **Lucknow session (1936)** and **Faizpur session (1937)**, Congress decided to participate in elections but postponed the decision on forming governments until after the elections.

Congress Rule in Provinces (1937-1939)

In **February 1937**, the **Indian National Congress** formed ministries in 7 of 11 provinces under the **Government of India Act of 1935**, ruling until **October 1939**. This marked a unique phase where Congress operated both as provincial governments and as an opposition to the **Central government** controlled by the British.

- **Congress Manifesto for Elections:** Rejection of the **1935 Act**. Promised **release of prisoners**, removal of **gender and caste-based disabilities**, **agrarian reforms**, including **rent reduction** and **rural debt relief & trade union rights** and the **right to strike**.
- **Congress Performance in Elections**
 - **Enfranchised:** 14% of the population (30.1 million, including 4.25 million women).
 - **Voter turnout:** 15.5 million, including 917,000 women.
 - **Seats won:** 716 out of 1,161 contested (out of 1,585 total).
 - **Majority in most provinces**, except Bengal, Assam, Punjab, Sindh, and NWFP.
 - It emerged as the **largest party** in Bengal, Assam, and NWFP.

- **Congress Ministries Provinces governed:** Bombay, Madras, Central Provinces, Orissa, United Provinces, Bihar. Later extended to **NWFP and Assam**.
- **Gandhi's Guidance:** Urged Congress leaders to hold offices "**lightly, not tightly**". Described the offices as "**crowns of thorns**", to be used for advancing **nationalist goals**. Highlighted the opportunity to demonstrate **Indians' capability for self-governance**.

Work Under Congress Ministries (1937-1939)

The formation of **Congress ministries** in the provinces had a transformative impact on the political climate. Despite **structural limitations**, including restricted powers and financial resources, Congress aimed to showcase its leadership and deliver on the promises of **Swaraj** (self-rule).

- **Civil Liberties Under Congress Rule (1937-1939)**
 - **Repealed emergency powers** (1932), including **Public Safety Acts**.
 - Lifted bans on organisations (**Hindustan Seva Dal, Youth Leagues**), books, and journals.
 - **Removed press restrictions**, restored **blacklisted newspapers**.
 - **Returned confiscated arms, licences**, curbed **police powers**.
 - Released **political prisoners**, revoked **deportation orders** (including **Kakori Conspiracy** revolutionaries).
 - **Restored confiscated land** in Bombay and **pensions** for Civil Disobedience Movement officials.
 - **Shortcomings:** **Arrests of Yusuf Meherally** (Madras, inflammatory speech), **S.S. Batliwala** (Madras, seditious speech). **CID surveillance** on leftists in Bombay (K.M. Munshi).
- **Agrarian Reforms Under Congress Ministries (1937-1939)**
 - **U.P. Tenancy Act (1939):** Full hereditary rights for tenants, limited landlord powers.
 - **Abolished forced labour (begar)** and illegal levies (**nazrana**).
 - **Orissa Tenancy Bill (1938):** Free transfer of occupancy holdings, reduced rent arrears interest (12.5% to 6%).
 - **Debt Relief Acts:** Regulated **moneylenders**, reduced interest, provided relief in **U.P., Orissa**.
 - **Madras Proposals** (T. Prakasam): Recognized **cultivators as landowners**; reforms not enacted due to ministry resignation.
 - **Constraints:** **Limited powers** under 1935 Act, **financial constraints**, need to **conciliate zamindars**. **Opposition** in legislative councils, **complex agrarian structure**.

- **Attitude Towards Labour (1937-1939)**
 - **Pro-Labour Stance:** Promoted **industrial peace**, **worker's rights**, and **conciliation**.
 - **Key Legislation:**
 - ◆ **Industrial Disputes Act (1938):** Promoted **conciliation** over strikes, empowered **Court of Industrial Arbitration**.
 - ◆ **Labour Enquiry Committee** (led by **Rajendra Prasad**): Recommendations included **wage increases**, **maternity benefits**, and **labour recruitment reforms**.
 - **Challenges & Criticism:** Repressive measures (Section 144, arrests) against militant trade union protests. **Nehru's discontent** with repressive actions but supported ministries. **Gandhi's opposition** to violent methods and reliance on colonial laws.
- **Social Welfare Reforms (1937-1939)**
 - **Harijan Advancement:** Laws for **temple entry**, **public facility access**, **scholarships**, and **representation**.
 - **Education:** Focus on **primary**, **technical**, and **higher education**, especially for **Harijans** and **girls**.
 - **Public Health:** Improved **sanitation**, public health measures.
 - **Khadi Support:** Subsidies for **khadi**, **spinning**, and **village industries**.
 - **Prison Reforms:** Improved prison conditions.
 - **National Planning Committee (1938):** **Subhas Chandra Bose** led structured development planning.
- **Extra-Parliamentary Mass Activity**
 - **Mass Engagement:** Literacy campaigns, **Congress police stations**, **panchayats**, **Grievance Committees**. Effective coordination in **Uttar Pradesh**, **village Congress committees**.

Resignation of Congress Ministries

Resigned in October-November 1939 in protest against Lord Linlithgow's decision to involve India in WWII without public consent. Post-resignation: Increased industrial unrest and difficulty meeting public expectations.

EVENTS PRECEDING THE SECOND WORLD WAR

Disarray in the Wake of Civil Disobedience

- **Gandhi's Discontent: Corruption and Indiscipline:** Post-civil disobedience, Gandhi noted a decline in ethical conduct and self-sacrifice within Congress, perceiving a rise in corruption and indiscipline. **Leadership Rivalries:** Infighting and power struggles complicated internal dynamics, with Gandhi lamenting that petty squabbles overshadowed national interests.

- **Membership and Ethics: Bogus Membership:** Gandhi criticised the inflation of membership numbers to manipulate internal elections and steer the movement's direction. **Unethical Practices:** Underhanded tactics to control Congress committees contradicted his principles of honesty and transparency.
- **Gandhi's Philosophy: Need for Internal Cleansing:** He believed Congress should prioritise self-reform and adhere to **Satyagraha** before confronting colonial rule. **Mass Mood:** Sensing fatigue among the masses, Gandhi argued that initiating a movement without widespread support would be ill-timed and ineffective.

Subhash Bose's Views: Haripura and Tripuri Sessions

- **Bose's Foundation in the Congress:**
 - **Provincial Leadership:** As **President** of the **Bengal Provincial Congress Committee**, Subhash Chandra Bose played a pivotal role in organising **youth** and promoting the **trade union movement**.
- **Ideological Stance and Actions:**
 - **Disagreements with Congress Leadership:** Bose often clashed with other **Congress leaders**, particularly **Gandhi**, over the intensity and nature of the **freedom struggle**.
 - **Opposition to Dominion Status:** Along with **Jawaharlal Nehru**, he opposed the **Motilal Nehru Report** advocating **dominion status**, calling instead for **complete independence**.
 - **Announcement of the Independence League:** Bose announced the establishment of the **Independence League**, highlighting his commitment to immediate and unqualified freedom from **British rule**.
- **The Haripura Congress Session (1938):** In **February 1938**, Bose was unanimously elected **President** during the **Haripura session**, reflecting significant support within the Congress.
- **Vision of Empowerment:**
 - **Congress Ministries as Revolutionary:** In his **presidential address**, Bose emphasised the revolutionary potential of **Congress ministries** at the provincial level.
 - **Economic Planning:** He stressed **economic development** through **planning**, leading to the establishment of a **National Planning Committee**.
 - **Solidarity with the Princely States:** The session resolved to extend **moral support** to those agitating against **autocratic governance** in **princely states**.
 - **Precursor to War:** Recognizing the disturbed **international situation**, Bose foresaw the potential of the approaching **war** to benefit **India's independence struggle**.
- **The Tripuri Congress Session (1939):** Despite Gandhi's reservations, Bose decided to contest for the presidency again, representing progressive and radical ideologies.

- **Election Victory:** He won with substantial support from the **Congress Socialist Party** and **communists**, garnering **1580 votes** against **Pattabhi Sitaramayya 1377**. **Gandhi** acknowledged Bose's victory but regarded Sitaramayya's defeat as his own loss.
- **Gandhi vs. Bose:** Bose's re-election highlighted significant **ideological polarisation** within the Congress. His critique of the **working committee's compromises** with the British led to the resignation of several committee members.
- **Bose at Tripuri:** Despite his poor health, Bose attended the **Tripuri session**, where he called for an **ultimatum** to the British for India's **independence**. He proposed a **six-month ultimatum** to the British, followed by a mass **civil disobedience movement** if unmet.
- **Gandhi's Caution:** Gandhi opposed the **ultimatum**, citing **internal divisions**, **communal discord**, and the Congress's **unpreparedness** for struggle.
- **Resolution and Resignation:** A resolution by **Govind Ballabh Pant** urged Bose to align with **Gandhi's wishes**, reflecting a preference for **Gandhi's leadership**. Despite efforts, Bose could not secure **Gandhi's support** or unify Congress around his **radical vision**. Faced with ideological isolation, Bose resigned in **April 1939**, paving the way for **Rajendra Prasad's** presidency.
- **The Aftermath and Forward Bloc Formation**
 - **Formation of Forward Bloc:** On **May 3, 1939**, Bose, along with his followers, formed the **Forward Bloc** within the Congress in **Makur, Unnao**, aiming to pursue his **radical approach** to achieving **independence**.
 - **Disciplinary Actions:** Following Bose's call for an **all-India protest**, the **Congress Working Committee** took disciplinary action in **August 1939**, as the protest was against the **AICC directive**. Bose was removed from his position as **President of the Bengal Provincial Congress Committee** and barred from holding any **elective office** in the Congress for **three years**.
 - **Solidarity with China:** At the **Tripuri session**, Congress passed a resolution expressing **solidarity with China** in its fight against **imperialism**, underscoring the Congress's broader **anti-imperialist stance**.
- **Indian Discontent:** This unilateral decision caused discontent within the **Indian National Congress**, the principal voice for India's **independence**.
- **Congress's Conditional Support:** Despite its disapproval of the British action, Congress conditionally supported the **Allied war efforts**. Key **conditions** were:
 - **Post-war Constituent Assembly:** Congress demanded that after the war, a **constituent assembly** be formed to chart the future of a **free India**.
 - **Responsible Government at the Centre:** Congress insisted on the immediate establishment of a **truly responsible government** at the Centre.
- **Viceroy's Rejection:** **Viceroy Linlithgow** rejected these conditions, despite Congress's argument that these steps were crucial to secure **public support** for the war effort.
- **Views of leaders:**
 - **Gandhi** preferred to avoid an **immediate mass struggle**, advocating for **unity** and political work among the masses, leaving space for **negotiation**.
 - **Nehru's Conditional Support:** **Nehru** called for **complete independence** before offering any support to the **British war effort**. His stance was one of **conditional support**, prioritising **sovereignty** over cooperation.
 - **Subhas Bose** and socialists like **Acharya Narendra Dev** and **Jayaprakash Narayan** saw the war as an **imperialist conflict** and proposed a **civil disobedience movement** to push for India's **independence**.
- **CWC Meeting at Wardha (September, 1939):**
 - On **October 23, 1939**, the **Congress Working Committee** rejected Linlithgow's statement, seeing it as continued **imperialism**. The CWC condemned **Fascist aggression**, asserting India couldn't fight for **democratic freedom** while being denied the same. The CWC demanded Britain end **imperialism** and establish **democracy** in India, urging clear **war aims** regarding India's **post-war freedom**.
- **Government's Attitude and Congress Ministries' Resignation**
 - The British government aimed to maintain **colonial control** during WWII.
 - On **October 17, 1939**, **Viceroy Linlithgow** refused to define **war aims** regarding India's **independence**, opting to consult **princely states and communities**, which Congress saw as a strategy to **divide** and weaken its authority.
 - In protest, **Congress ministries resigned on 23rd October, 1939** from provinces, signalling a serious escalation in the **nationalist struggle** for **self-determination**.

[UPSC 2012]

SECOND WORLD WAR AND NATIONALISTIC RESPONSE

- **Outbreak of War:** On **September 1, 1939**, **World War II** began when **Germany attacked Poland**. On **September 3, 1939**, the **British Government of India** declared India's support for the war without consulting Indian opinion.

- **Ramgarh Session (1940):** At the Ramgarh session in March 1940, under Maulana Abul Kalam Azad, Congress reiterated **complete independence** as non-negotiable, rejecting **dominion status** and considering **civil disobedience** if necessary.

There was consensus on the need for a **movement**, but disagreement on its **form**:

- **Gandhi** favoured continued provincial cooperation and offered **moral support** to the British on a **non-violent basis**.
- **Nehru** insisted on **complete independence** as a precondition for Congress's support for the **war effort**.
- **Subhas Bose** advocated **direct action** against the colonial government, urging India to seize Britain's **vulnerability** during the war.
- **Congress Declaration:** Only **complete independence** would be accepted. **Rejected dominion status** within the imperial structure. Civil disobedience would be launched when deemed necessary.
- **Muslim League's Pakistan Resolution (Lahore, March 1940)**
 - Advocated for the creation of **independent states** in **Muslim-majority areas**.
 - Called for **autonomous and sovereign constituent units**.
 - Demanded **safeguards** for Muslims in **minority areas**.

AUGUST OFFER (AUGUST 1940)

Background

Hitler's astounding success and the fall of Belgium, Holland, and France put England in a conciliatory mood. Both Gandhi and Nehru strongly opposed the idea of taking advantage of Britain's position. The Congress was ready to compromise, asking the British government to let it form an interim government during the war period but the government was not interested. It came up with its own offer to get the cooperation of India in the war effort by announcing the August Offer (August 1940) which proposed:

Key Proposals in the August Offer

- **Dominion Status:** For the first time, dominion status for India was explicitly stated as a post-war objective.
- **Expansion of Viceroy's Executive Council:** The council would include a **majority of Indian members** from major political parties.
- **Constituent Assembly:** A post-war constituent assembly, mainly composed of Indians, would decide India's future constitution.
- **Minority Rights Protection:** No future constitution would be adopted without the consent of **minorities**, mainly aimed at assuring the **Muslim League**.

Responses to the August Offer

- **Congress:** Rejected the offer, viewing **dominion status** as outdated. **Nehru** famously declared it "as dead as a doornail", and **Gandhi** believed it widened the gap between the British and nationalist aspirations.
- **Muslim League:** Welcomed the offer, especially the assurance of a **veto for minorities**, seeing it as a step towards their demand for **partition**.

INDIVIDUAL SATYAGRAHA (1940-41)

- The British government issued **ordinances** restricting freedom of speech, press, and assembly.
- Insisted on no constitutional progress until Congress and the Muslim League reached an agreement.
- **Gandhi** initiated the movement in late 1940, with a **limited satyagraha** strategy.
- **Objective:** Show nationalist strength and patience, protest against the war, and highlight parallels between **Nazism** and British colonial rule.

Key Features

- **Freedom of Speech:** Satyagrahis demanded freedom to make anti-war declarations.
- **Delhi Chalo Movement:** If not arrested, satyagrahis would march to **Delhi**, escalating the protest.
- **Prominent Satyagrahis:** **Vinoba Bhave** was the first, followed by **Jawaharlal Nehru**.
- By **May 1941**, around 25,000 people had been arrested for civil disobedience.

CRIPPS MISSION (MARCH 1942)

The **Cripps Mission**, led by **Stafford Cripps** in March 1942, aimed to secure **Indian cooperation** for the British war effort against the Axis powers, driven by the imminent **Japanese threat** and pressure from Allies to resolve India's political deadlock.

Main Proposals

- **Dominion Status:** Proposed an Indian Union with dominion status, allowing free relationships within the Commonwealth and participation in the United Nations. [UPSC 2016]
- **Constituent Assembly:** Suggested a post-war assembly with elected members from provincial legislatures and nominees from princely states.
- **British Government Conditions:**
 - Provinces not joining the Union could establish a separate constitution. Any Province, which is not prepared to accept the new Constitution would have the right to sign a separate agreement with Britain regarding its future status. [UPSC 2022]
 - Negotiation of a treaty for the **transfer of power**.

- **Interim Period:** British retained control over **defence** and the Governor-General's powers.

Key Departures from Past Proposals

- Placed the constitution-making process entirely in Indian hands.
- Acknowledged the possibility of provinces forming separate unions and allowed for **exiting the Commonwealth**.
- Offered a preliminary blueprint for partition.

Reactions to the Cripps Mission

- **Congress Rejection:** Leaders **Nehru** and **Azad** rejected the proposal for not providing complete independence. Criticised representation methods for princely states and the right to secession, which threatened national unity. Opposed lack of immediate power transfer and the retention of the Governor-General's supremacy.
- **Muslim League Critique:** Opposed the idea of a single Indian Union and criticised the procedures for the constituent assembly, rejecting the denial of Pakistan as a separate nation.

- **Other Groups' Concerns:** Various groups, including **Liberals**, **Hindu Mahasabha**, **Sikhs**, and **depressed classes**, voiced concerns about the right to secession and the potential impact on India's unity.

Reasons for Failure

- **Inflexibility:** Cripps's rigid "take it or leave it" stance hampered negotiations.
- **Veto Powers:** Disputes over the Viceroy's veto powers created a deadlock.
- **British Opposition:** Leaders like **Churchill** undermined the mission's effectiveness.
- **Implementation Uncertainties:** Questions regarding the execution and interpretation of the treaty hindered progress.

Aftermath

- Gandhi described the proposals as a "**post-dated cheque on a crashing bank**."
- Nehru criticised the mission as a **continuation of autocratic rule**.
- The mission's failure escalated Indian frustrations and fueled the demand for **immediate action** against British imperialism, culminating in the **Quit India Movement**.



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